



"The Government should launch an all-out offensive, a fight to the finish. The BJP will support the Government."

RAJIV PRATAP RUDY *BJP leader*

after the horrific Dantewada attack, he has an opportunity.

■ BEEF UP STATE POLICE

Invest more in training of manpower and better equipment

Little has been done to fill the empty boots on the ground. The six Naxal-affected states have 1.3 lakh vacant police posts—more than one-fourth of the total police vacancies in the country. On an average, there were eight policemen per police station, when the requirement is for at least 100 per police station in Naxal-affected areas, says

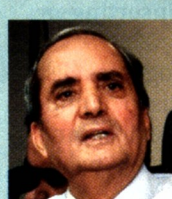
seven states that are under the scanner. These need to be drawn from within local police forces and fresh battalions need to be raised from within the states. These forces need to be trained in the 20 jungle warfare schools which the MHA is building.

It's not just the state police forces. Even the bulk of Central forces are not trained. They could be doing election duty one day, and be pushed into forests of Dantewada the next day, expected to taken on highly motivated, well-trained and equipped Maoists.

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MOST OF THE STATES AFFECTED BY LEFT WING EXTREMISM DO NOT EVEN HAVE POLICE TRAINING SCHOOLS. BIHAR HAD BEEN UNABLE TO ESTABLISH ONE IN THE PAST 10 YEARS.

suggests options for the way forward



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● Disconnect between the 'general' and 'specifics' of a counter-insurgency operation

● It was a badly planned operation in which force deployment was disregarded

● Mismatch between the magnitude of the challenge and capacities deployed

● Vast region with dense forest cover, little governance and a population in extreme poverty

● Constant review of counter-Maoist strategies and policies needed

● Greater coordination between the Centre and Maoist-affected states

● Build technical, human intelligence

● Target Maoist capacities by reorienting police forces through training and equipment

● Focus on intelligence-led operations targeting Maoist leadership

Home Secretary G.K. Pillai. The sole college of counter insurgency and jungle warfare in Kanker, Chhattisgarh, is inadequate for training the police and paramilitary forces required for this new war on the Naxals.

Most of the states affected by Left Wing Extremism do not even have police training schools. Bihar had been unable to establish one in the past 10 years after the existing school went to Jharkhand. "Army officers and institutions and ex-servicemen need to be involved more proactively in their training and in higher command," says G. Parthasarathy.

"Keep your weapon by your side at all times..." a Maoist infantry training manual exhorts the cadres. It is a basic message that is lost on police personnel. In the February attack on Silda camp where the Maoists killed 24 policemen and looted their weapons, the East Frontier Rifles policemen had dutifully deposited their rifles in the armoury. Rifle discipline is something that comes with intensive training, something the police forces sorely lack. "We are training like policemen, the Maoists are training like the Indian Army," says a senior police official. It is not enough to give the security personnel weapons. There is need to create Greyhounds-styled dedicated forces (see box) for counter-Maoist operations in the

Special Action Force (earlier called Cobra battalions). There are only seven such battalions under the CRPF while Home Ministry officials project a requirement for at least 15 more battalions with over 1,000 men each.

■ BUILD GRASSROOTS INTEL

This is critical to nail the Maoists and curb attacks on installations.

"Special forces are like guided missiles," says an Indian Army Parachute regiment officer. "If you don't feed them correct coordinates into them, there is no chance of them ever hitting the target." In Jammu and Kashmir and the North-east, the army and the paramilitary forces have operated after painstakingly building contacts and gathering local intelligence.

If the Central paramilitary forces are to move on their new mantra of 'intelligence based operations' against the Maoists, they will need surveillance and intelligence assessment capabilities like human intelligence or HUMINT and technical intelligence or TECHINT from unmanned aerial vehicles, helicopters and airships.

This is a critical requirement that calls for years of staying in Maoist-affected areas and diligently building networks of informants. Both the state and Central intelligence cadres